words], and enter Kabul or fight the enemy beneath its walls, expressing his own earnest hope that the General, now that he had been reinforced by the fresh troops from the Bala Hisar, would adopt this clear and obvious course'.[112] Again Shelton and Elphinstone opposed all his plans, seeming more determined than ever to march out of Afghanistan as quickly as possible. 'The forts were the same evening given up and immediately occupied by Afghans,' added Lawrence. 'The Envoy and I stood on a mound near the mosque whilst they were being evacuated by our men, and I am not ashamed to say that it was with eyes moistened with tears from grief and indignation, we witnessed these strongholds, the last prop of our tottering power in Kabul, which it had cost us so much blood to seize and defend, made over, one after another, to our treacherous and exulting enemies.'[113]

Then, without warning, a small chink of light and hope appeared. On 20 November, Nizam al-Daula, the Prime Minister Macnaghten had foisted on Shuja, sent news that his old patron, Nawab Zaman Khan, the Barakzai leader who had initially taken on the leadership of the revolt, 'was offended because of the people rallying around Mohammad Akbar, and sent word that he wanted to become an ally of the English. The English, who sought safety from the sharp edge of Afghan swords, considered the Nizam al-Daula's letter tidings from heaven.'[114] At the same time, news came that many of the rebel troops were discontented with Akbar Khan due to the high price of food.[115]

Macnaghten immediately embarked on a renewed attempt to divide and rule. Desperate to avoid the potential catastrophe of a midwinter retreat through hostile mountains, he tried various schemes at once, 'grasping at every new combination that seemed to promise more hope than the last'. Through Mohan Lal, both the Qizilbash and the Ghilzai chieftains were offered the large sum of 20,000 rupees to break with the rebels and rally to the support of the British. 'If any portion of the Afghans wish our troops to remain in the country,' he declared, 'I shall think myself at liberty to break the engagement which I have made to go away, which engagement was made believing it to be in accordance with the wishes of the Afghan nation.'

But Macnaghten was hopelessly out of his depth. 'It is very difficult to know what to do,' he wrote in confusion to Mohan Lal at this time.[116] He didn't understand the strength of the marriage ties which linked the Ghilzais to Akbar Khan, nor did he even begin to comprehend the degree to which